

Chapter 62: Heart Disease

After finishing speaking, Chu Qingqiu touched the tip of her sword and rose into the air, stopping outside the crack with her hands clasped behind her back.

Ning Fuyi's eyes suddenly felt a bit sore. These were the words she had desperately wanted to hear in her previous life. Every time she fell into the abyss, how much she had wanted to hear someone say to her: "Don't be afraid, I'm here."

She turned to face the endless gale of wind and blood rain, said nothing more, bent her knees, and rode Xiangsi swiftly downward. Blown somewhat unsteadily by the wind, after landing, she reached out to check the woman's breathing.

The woman had suffered backlash from forcibly destroying Chi Du's bones and was now unconscious, but her life was temporarily safe. Ning Fuyi didn't delay any longer, hoisted the person onto her shoulder, turned around and rushed back to the crack.

The moment she flew out of the crack, bricks and rubble came crashing down at her head. Ning Fuyi held her breath to avoid the sand and dust, spinning twice in mid-air before barely managing to land.

Under the moonlight, earth-shaking roars came from behind her, accompanied by the screams of palace attendants. The originally magnificent study was instantly reduced to ruins.

Ning Fuyi sneezed several times in the flying dust before her nose felt better.

The palace attendants scattered throughout the courtyard didn't know what had happened. Seeing the "Empress" unconscious in Ning Fuyi's hands, they all shouted "Assassin!" and "Save Her Majesty!" So palace guards came rushing from all directions. Fearing that taking action would harm innocent lives, Chu Qingqiu only waved out two white silk ribbons to temporarily block them.

At the same time, she waved her hand and cast a white light over the "Empress." So under everyone's terrified gazes, the originally familiar face began to change - the eyes became more upturned and elongated, the nose bridge higher, and the red lips fuller.

The biggest change was her head of black hair, which began to turn silver-white from the roots, finally cascading over her shoulders like fallen snow, spilling onto the ground.

Beautiful yet bewitching.

Seeing this, the guards stopped their raised long swords in mid-air, retreating in terror and bumping into each other in a pile.

"What, what, what kind of monster is this!"

"It's a demon! Run!"

The people's shouts rose and fell. Ning Fuyi's ears hurt from listening. Just then, another group of people appeared beyond the corridor. From the weapons they carried, they were clearly not ordinary people.

Ning Fuyi looked over and suddenly smiled. It was Liu Wenzhu with an anxious face, wielding her thousand-pound hammer, pushing through the crowd and hurrying toward Ning Fuyi. Her usually neat hair was as disheveled as seaweed.

"Yiyi!" She stopped breathlessly in front of Ning Fuyi. Looking down at the "Empress" who had recovered her original appearance on the ground, she was so frightened that she quickly pulled Ning Fuyi behind her, frowning deeply. "She really is a demon!"

"She's already unconscious, no harm." Ning Fuyi spoke to comfort her. She glanced at Chu Qingqiu and asked, "We haven't sent out any messages yet. How did you come so quickly?"

"I've been restless ever since you entered the palace, afraid that if something really dangerous happened and I went to get help then, it might delay things. So I borrowed people from the Liu family in advance to guard around the imperial city. As soon as we heard any disturbance, we'd come immediately." Liu Wenzhu breathed a sigh of relief.

"Just now I heard the commotion and felt the ground trembling, so I thought it might be you two. Without hesitation, I broke through the palace gates."

"Moreover, after entering the palace, I discovered that the barrier that originally absorbed immortal power seemed to be gradually failing!" Liu Wenzhu said, spreading her palm to show a burst of flames rising from it.

"Your timing is perfect." Ning Fuyi smiled. She pointed to the ruins behind her. "We might need to trouble your people to clean this up. We still have some questions for this empress."

This was Liu Wenzhu's first time participating in such a major event. Her face was flushed with excitement as she waved her delicate hand and led the Liu family people to clean up the mess.

Meanwhile, Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu brought the woman back to her bedchamber. The bedchamber was still quiet inside, and Qiu Yi, who was tied up at the foot of the bed, immediately kicked her legs and shouted when she saw the two.

Chu Qingqiu waved her hand to cut through her ropes. She stumbled to her feet, and upon seeing the woman being dragged by Ning Fuyi, was so frightened she nearly sat down.

"Master, you're out. This..."

"This is the fake empress." Ning Fuyi took over the conversation. She released her grip, and the woman rolled to the ground, her white hair scattered, unconscious.

Qiu Yi stared wide-eyed at the woman's face, her mouth agape, saying nothing.

After the woman returned to her original form, the strange fragrance on her body became even more intense. Within the rich scent, there was also a smell that wasn't very obvious but impossible to ignore.

After catching this scent, Chu Qingqiu also showed a moment of shock and understanding.

"Venerable, it seems to be demonic qi¹." Ning Fuyi bent down to smell, her heart suddenly alert, her phoenix eyes slightly raised as she looked at Qiu Yi.

"And this demonic qi is very familiar." Ning Fuyi stared at Qiu Yi, saying softly.

Qiu Yi backed up two steps, clenched her fists, and didn't dare look at Ning Fuyi anymore.

However, Ning Fuyi didn't say more. She stood up and watched as Chu Qingqiu approached and used immortal power to wake the woman.

Blood water gushed from the corner of the woman's mouth, the bright red liquid flowing down her jade-white skin to the ground. Then she gasped softly and opened her eyes.

Her pupils weren't those of ordinary people, but presented a clear copper color, calm and soul-stirring. Her elongated eyes looked around in a circle, and she curved her lips as she slowly leaned against the edge of the bed.

Her arms and legs lay together weakly, beautiful and bewitching.

"I've long heard that Divine Venerable Chu Ling cares for all living beings, but I never expected the Venerable would even be willing to save a demon." She wiped the blood from her lips. "Or does the Venerable think I died too easily and want your immortal sects to judge me?"

"This venerable didn't save you. For those who seek death, this venerable never speaks much." Chu Qingqiu said.

"Not the Venerable." The woman's eyes flowed and landed on Ning Fuyi, whom she had never paid attention to before. After looking at her for a few moments, she burst into laughter.

"Where is the real empress?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"What, can't the Venerable's power find even one person?" The woman curved her lips.

"This venerable can find her, but this venerable still wants to ask you." Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

The woman lowered her eyes and slowly smoothed her blood-red dress: "In the ancient well of the imperial garden. I placed a barrier - she won't die."

Upon hearing this, Ning Fuyi quickly called for one of the Liu family members from outside, asking him to lead people to rescue her. After that person flashed away, she looked back into the room.

Chu Qingqiu was still questioning: "What grudge do you have with Chi Du? And how did you know that Chi Du's tomb exists beneath this Qi Kingdom palace?"

"My grudge with Chi Du has nothing to do with your immortal sects. You don't need to know." The woman spoke calmly. "As for how I knew, this place was originally my home. How could I not know?"

Upon hearing this, Ning Fuyi fell into thought. Qi Kingdom's history spanned several hundred years, and this place had excellent location. Even thousands of years ago, it was mortal territory. If the woman's words weren't false, could she also be from ancient times?

"Was that barrier your handiwork? And why are you so obsessed with young men and women? Have you..." Chu Qingqiu hesitated, ultimately unable to say that word, changing it to, "harmed innocents?"

The woman answered every question, her body soft and limp with a resigned feeling: "The barrier was because of Chi Du, not me. If I had such great ability, why would I still need the Venerable to help me open the coffin?"

"As for young men and women." The woman tapped her lips with fingers stained with rouge². "I am a demon creature and must absorb sexual energy³ to survive. But rest assured, Venerable, I never harm lives. I just need them to lie beside me while I absorb a little from each person - it's enough for me to live."

As she spoke, she looked toward Qiu Yi, but saw Qiu Yi backing away repeatedly with a face full of resentment. So she moved her contemptuous gaze back to Chu Qingqiu: "If the Venerable has other questions, ask them. Once you're done asking, you can send me on my way."

"Why are you so obsessed with death?" This time it was Ning Fuyi who couldn't help but speak quietly.

The woman didn't answer her question, didn't even lift her gaze.

"Two last questions." Chu Qingqiu's voice became gentler. "Where exactly did you learn my identity? And why did you..."

"Call this venerable ugly."

Upon hearing this, the woman suddenly couldn't help but smile. She laughed until her face had color, panting while shaking her head: "You'll have to ask your little disciple about that. If your disciple hadn't chatted with me for so many days, I really couldn't have guessed which one traveling with her was who."

As she spoke, she raised her hand. Ning Fuyi suddenly felt something burning on her wrist. She quickly rolled up her sleeve, revealing a prayer bead hanging on her fair wrist.

She shook her wrist, and a gem-like feather fell from it, burning to ash in mid-air.

At this time, Qiu Yi's face was even paler than the woman's. She bit her lip hard and was about to kneel before Chu Qingqiu, but Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to stop her.

Chu Qingqiu's expression was also poor, her dark eyebrows slightly furrowed, her skin taut - clearly holding back tremendous anger.

However, though she was angry, she never disciplined her disciple in front of outsiders. At this moment, she could only barely restrain herself, though the temperature around her body was so cold it was chilling, making even Ning Fuyi move away.

That woman's composure was admirable. Even facing such a Chu Qingqiu, she remained unchanged, even with smiling eyes.

"As for the last question, Venerable, are you certain you want to hear it in front of others?" the woman said.

Chu Qingqiu gripped her White Bone weapon tighter. After a while, she said "Go out."

Qiu Yi, whose eyes were already filled with tears, naturally didn't dare disobey. She turned and ran out the door. Ning Fuyi had wanted to stay and listen, but after meeting Chu Qingqiu's frosty gaze, she also obediently followed orders with downcast eyes.

Finally, only one person and one demon remained in the room.

"I won't hide it from the Venerable - I'm not an ordinary demon, but a demon beast. I judge whether people are beautiful not by their appearance, but by their scent." The woman rarely put away her casual attitude, her gaze falling on Chu Qingqiu.

"The more abundant one's vital energy and the healthier the body, the better the scent. Conversely, the more lacking in vital energy and the weaker the body, the more unbearable the scent."

"Forgive my bluntness, but Venerable's body... I'm afraid your time is limited." The woman said, a moment of compassion flashing in her eyes before being replaced by a smile. "However, I still can't tell what illness could torment you to such a state."

Chu Qingqiu quietly met her gaze, her expression initially showing some surprise, then turning to the calm of having already expected this.

"I have a heart disease⁴. Perhaps it's already terminal." Chu Qingqiu said.

"Indeed, among all the ailments in the world, only heart disease cannot be cured." The woman murmured, then extended her wrist toward Chu Qingqiu. "Venerable, please proceed."

Chu Qingqiu remained silent. White silk flew from her sleeve, wrapping the woman round and round like a cocoon. Finally, the white silk shrank, and the woman was sealed within it, becoming a small silk-faced pendant.

Chu Qingqiu stepped outside. Without her noticing, dawn had already broken, and the morning light was dazzling. She squinted as she looked at the red sun.

Ning Fuyi ran toward her with quick steps, her waist graceful and straight, her hands and feet long and elegant like a crane's, her hair like clouds, her dress hem fluttering youthfully behind her as she stopped in front of her.

"Venerable." She spoke.

Chu Qingqiu looked into those pair of jet-black phoenix eyes, then placed the pendant the woman had become into her hand: "Give this to Elder Pingyao. She will submit it to the Six Sects⁵."

"Alright." Ning Fuyi reached out to put the pendant into her prayer bead, then looked up with a smile. "Once we settle the remaining matters, shall we return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate?"

"Yes." Chu Qingqiu answered. Seeing that Ning Fuyi was about to turn and leave, she suddenly called out to stop her, "Wait."

Ning Fuyi turned back around, but Chu Qingqiu didn't speak. She just looked at her deeply several times, her soft white palm reaching out to brush away a withered leaf from the top of her head.

Finally, she arranged her hair, then lifted her chin slightly. The last two words were so light they were like inaudible wind.

"Go, Yiyi⁶."

Footnotes:

¹ **Demonic qi (魔气)** - In cultivation fiction, this refers to the dark spiritual energy associated with demonic cultivation or demon creatures

² **Rouge (丹蔻)** - Traditional Chinese cosmetic, specifically nail polish or finger stain made from garden balsam flowers

³ **Sexual energy (精气)** - In Chinese cultivation and traditional medicine, this refers to vital essence or life force, often with sexual/reproductive connotations

⁴ **Heart disease (心疾)** - In this context, likely refers to emotional/spiritual affliction rather than physical heart problems - diseases of the heart/emotions that cannot be cured by medicine

⁵ **Six Sects (六派)** - The six major immortal cultivation sects that govern the cultivation world in this story

⁶ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi, using the repetition of the "yi" character from her name